CAREER SKILLS COURSE · PART-TIME DIGITAL BUSINESS

Dropshipping Career Course

How to research, launch and run an online store that sells without holding stock, in 10 to 15 hours a week

English edition · For beginners with basic computer and internet skills · Prices are examples in US dollars

Important: this course teaches a business method. It does not promise any income. Results depend on your product choice, effort, market and luck. Laws, platform rules, tax and fees change, so always check the current official source before you act.

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INTRODUCTION

How to Use This Course

> **By the end of this introduction you will:** know who this course is for, how it is organised, and how to study it alongside a job or other commitments.

Who this course is for

This course is written for an ordinary person with basic knowledge: you can use a smartphone and a computer, send email, shop online and use social media. You do not need a business degree, coding skills or money to buy stock. You do need patience, honesty and a willingness to learn by testing.

Many students use dropshipping as a first step into digital work. The skills you build here (market research, product photography, online sales, paid advertising, customer service and data analysis) are valued by many employers and clients, so the course is also a career course.

What dropshipping is, in one sentence

Dropshipping is a way to sell physical products online where you never keep the stock yourself: when a customer buys from your store, you buy the same item from a supplier, who ships it directly to the customer under your brand.

How the course is organised

- **Chapters 1 to 3** explain the model, the time commitment and the basic setup.
- **Chapters 4 to 8** take you through finding a product, a supplier, a store and a product page.
- **Chapters 9 to 11** cover traffic, fulfilment, measurement and growth.
- **Chapter 12** is about law, ethics and risk. Please do not skip it.
- **Chapters 13 and 14** give you a 90-day plan and show how the skills become a career.
- **The appendix** holds a glossary, email templates and checklists you can print.

> **Study tip**
> Do not read the whole course first and then start. Read one chapter, complete its exercise in a notebook or spreadsheet, then move on. Each chapter ends with a practical task. Finishing the tasks is more valuable than reading quickly.

How to read the drawings

Diagrams appear wherever a picture explains a process better than words. Arrows show direction of money, goods or information. Colours are used consistently: **green** for money

coming in, **amber** for decisions or timing, and **blue** for information or data flow.

CHAPTER 1

Understanding Dropshipping

> **Learning goals:** explain the dropshipping order flow, list the money and goods flows, understand the advantages and the real disadvantages, and separate common myths from facts.

1.1 The dropshipping model

In a traditional shop, a retailer buys goods in bulk, stores them and sells them one by one. The retailer carries the cost of stock, space and unsold items. In dropshipping, the store owner (you) carries none of that. You only pay the supplier after a customer has paid you.

There are four parties in every dropshipping transaction:

- **The customer** who finds your store, buys a product and expects it to arrive.
- **The store owner** (you), who attracts the customer, sets the price, takes the payment and handles support.
- **The supplier** (manufacturer, wholesaler or dropshipping platform), who holds stock, packs the order and ships it.
- **The payment provider and the carrier**, who move the money and the parcel.

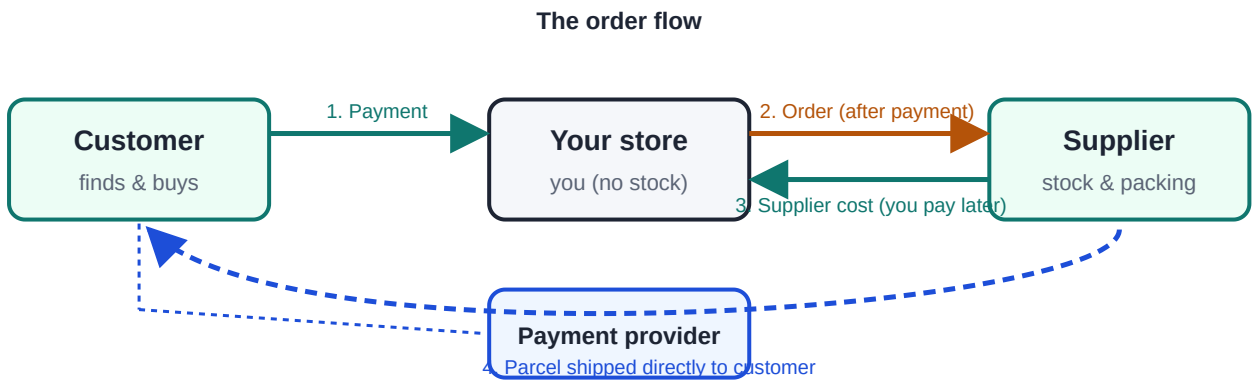


Figure 1.1 · The dropshipping order flow. Money goes to you first; you pay the supplier afterwards.

1.2 A simple example

Imagine you sell a stainless-steel water bottle for **$24.99**. The supplier charges you **$7.50** for the bottle plus shipping to the customer. A customer pays you $24.99 on your website. You then place the order with the supplier for $7.50 (including shipping). Your gross profit before advertising and fees is $17.49. Out of this, you must still pay advertising, payment fees, platform fees and any returns. Chapter 7 shows exactly how to calculate what remains.

1.3 Advantages

- **Low start-up cost.** You can test a store for a few hundred dollars instead of thousands in stock.
- **No warehouse.** Your home or a laptop is enough.
- **Flexible hours.** Orders are processed automatically, so you can work in short sessions.
- **Easy to test.** You can try a new product in a day and stop it in a day.
- **Skills transfer.** Marketing, data analysis and customer service are useful across many digital careers.

1.4 Disadvantages and risks

- **Thin margins.** Advertising and fees can eat most of the profit.
- **Less control.** You do not see the product before the customer does. Quality and delivery times depend on the supplier.
- **Long shipping times.** Some suppliers ship from abroad in 2 to 4 weeks. Customers may complain or ask for refunds.
- **Competition.** Many stores sell the same product using the same supplier photos.
- **Platform dependence.** Ad platforms or marketplaces can change rules or suspend accounts with little warning.
- **Reputation risk.** A poor supplier can damage your brand within weeks.

1.5 Myths and facts

Myth	Fact
"You can get rich in 30 days."	Most new stores lose money for the first months while they learn. Plan for at least 3 to 6 months of testing before judging a store.
"You don't need to know anything."	You need basic business, marketing and customer service skills. The course gives you these, but they must be practised.
"Winning products are secret and sold in courses."	Good products are found through systematic research and testing, which you will learn in Chapter 4. Be wary of anyone who sells a "secret winner list".
"Set up a store and the orders come by themselves."	Orders come only from traffic. Without marketing, a store is silent.
"Supplier photos are free to use."	Supplier photos often belong to someone else. Use them only with permission or replace them (Chapter 8).

Warning: the income claims trap

Many online adverts show screenshots of big sales and promise quick money. Those screenshots are often edited, reflect a single lucky product, or are paid for by someone trying to sell a course. Judge any claim by asking: where is the proof, what were the costs, and how long did it take?

Practical task 1

☐ Write, in your own words, the four parties in a dropshipping order and what each one does.

☐ Pick any product you have bought online recently and list the probable supplier, the price, and how long you waited for delivery.

☐ List three myths you believed before this chapter and write the fact that replaces each one.

CHAPTER 2

The Part-Time Business Model and Your Mindset

> **Learning goals:** decide how much time you can really give, set realistic income expectations, plan a weekly routine, and build the habits that keep a side business alive.

2.1 Choosing your time budget

A part-time dropshipping business typically needs **10 to 15 hours per week** in the first months, and often less once automated and optimised. Those hours are spent on research, store work, content, customer messages, and reviewing ad results. Be honest about your schedule. A plan that needs 25 hours but gets 6 will fail.

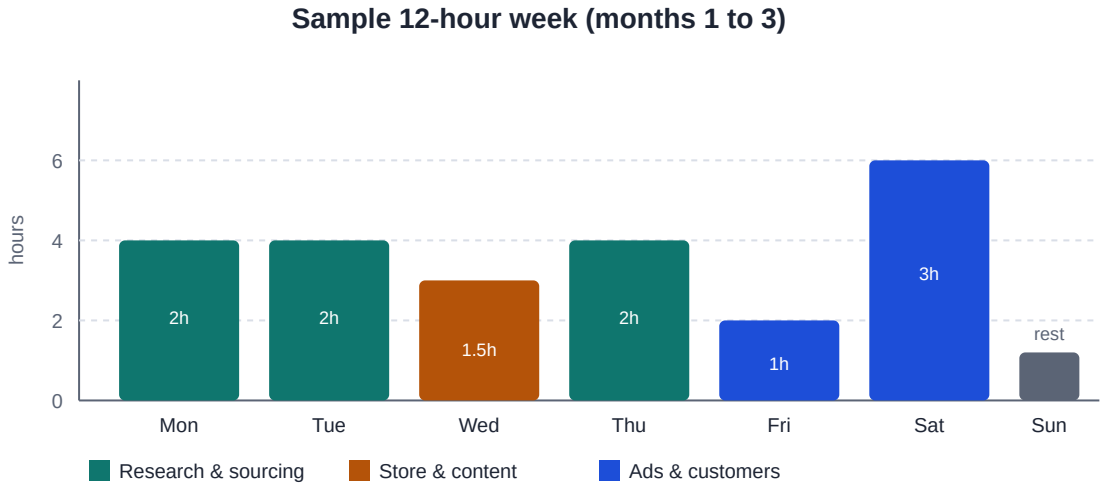


Figure 2.1 · One way to split a part-time week. Adjust to your own life; keep one rest day.

2.2 Realistic income expectations

Your first goal is **not** a salary. Your first goal is to learn whether a product, an audience and a price can work together. A realistic progression looks like this:

Stage	Typical timing	What success looks like
Learning	Weeks 1 to 4	Store is live, first research done, first ads tested. Spending may exceed sales.
Testing	Months 2 to 4	Some products earn a profit after ad costs. You know your best channel and your customer.
Stabilising	Months 5 to 9	A small number of repeat products, steady orders, and a routine that takes few hours a week.
Growing	Months 10 and later	Consistent profit, or a decision to scale, sell the store, or move your skills to clients.

Many part-time stores never reach the "stabilising" stage. That is normal. Even then, you will have gained paid-ad, analytics and customer-service skills that can be sold as a service (Chapter 14).

2.3 The mindset that works

- **Think like a tester, not a gambler.** Every product is an experiment with a budget, a time limit and a stop rule.
- **Keep numbers, not feelings.** A product you love may lose money. A product you find boring may pay your bills.
- **Protect your reputation.** Customers judge the brand, not the supplier.
- **Accept small losses.** Losses in the testing phase are tuition. Set a maximum you can afford to lose and keep to it.
- **Separate money from life.** Do not use rent money or borrowed money to fund ads.

2.4 Building a routine

A part-time business survives on routine. Choose two fixed sessions per week, for example Tuesday and Saturday mornings, and protect them like a job. Use the first session for research and planning, and the second for building and reviewing. Spend 10 minutes each morning checking messages and orders. Keep a weekly log: hours worked, tasks finished, money spent, money earned. Review it every Sunday.

> **Tip: avoid the tool trap**
>
> Beginners often spend weeks comparing themes, apps and courses. Tools matter far less than actions. Choose a simple setup in Chapter 3, and spend your energy on testing products and talking to customers.

Practical task 2

☐ Write your available hours per week for the next three months. Be strict: subtract work, family and sleep.

☐ Set two fixed weekly work sessions in your calendar, with a reminder.

☐ Decide your monthly testing budget (for example $150) and the most you could lose in total before you stop (for example $600).

CHAPTER 3

Setting Up the Business: Legal, Tax and Tools

> **Learning goals:** choose a simple legal set-up, separate your money, understand the basic tax duties in general terms, and select a minimum toolkit.

> **Important disclaimer**
>
> Business registration, tax and consumer law depend on your country and state or province. This chapter gives general guidance and the questions to ask. Before you take money from customers, confirm the requirements with your local tax office, business registration office or a qualified accountant.

3.1 Choosing a legal form

Most part-time sellers begin in one of these ways:

Option	Typical use	Things to check
Sole trader / sole proprietor / self-employed	Simplest route for one person in many countries	Registration with the tax authority; personal liability for debts; reporting of income
Partnership	Two or more people sharing work and profit	A written agreement on shares, duties and exit terms
Limited company (LLC, Ltd, etc.)	Later, when profit is steady or liability protection matters	Higher setup and annual costs; accounting rules

For a first test, the simplest registration you are allowed to use is usually enough. You can change structure later if the business grows.

3.2 Money management basics

- **Open a separate bank account** or a business sub-account for all sales, ad spend and supplier payments.
- **Use a business card** for ads and tools. This makes records and cards disputes easier.
- **Keep every receipt** in a folder or cloud drive. Name files by date and supplier.
- **Set aside tax money.** Move a fixed percentage of each profit into a savings account so that tax is not a surprise.

3.3 Tax in general terms

Depending on where you live, you may need to:

- register for sales tax, VAT or GST if your sales pass a threshold or if you sell in a regulated market;
- report business income and allowable expenses (ads, tools, samples, some internet costs) in your annual tax return;
- collect and pass on the correct tax on each order, often shown as a separate line at checkout.

Ask your platform how it handles tax on orders. Many platforms can calculate it for you, but you remain responsible for registration and filing.

3.4 Your minimum toolkit

You can start with a small set of tools. Costs change often, so check current prices on the official websites before buying.

Need	Examples	Why it matters
Online store	Shopify, WooCommerce (WordPress), Wix, Square Online	Your shop front and checkout
Product research	Google Trends, TikTok search and Creative Center, Amazon bestseller pages, AliExpress and Temu listings, Meta Ad Library	Shows demand and competitor activity
Supplier platform	CJdropshipping, Spocket, Zendrop, or a direct supplier	Imports listings and sends orders
Ad platforms	Meta Ads (Facebook and Instagram), TikTok Ads, Google Ads	Brings visitors to your store
Spreadsheet	Google Sheets or Excel	Price calculator, product tracker, weekly log
Email	Built-in store email, Klaviyo, Mailchimp	Abandoned-cart emails, newsletters
Customer messages	Shared inbox, Tidio or store chat, WhatsApp Business	Fast answers build trust
Design	Canva, phone editing apps	Banners, simple videos, ad creatives

> **Tip: use free trials carefully**
>
> Many platforms offer a free trial. Write the end date in your calendar the day you start. Cancel any tool you have not used in two weeks.

3.5 Your business name and brand basics

Choose a name that is easy to say, spell and find. Check three things before you commit: the domain name is available, the name is not already a registered trademark in your market (search the national trademark database), and the social media handle is free. Keep a simple brand sheet with the name, two colours, one font and a short tone of voice (for example: "friendly, clear, practical").

Practical task 3

☐ Find the business registration rules for your country or state. Write down the form, the cost, and the office that handles it.

☐ Open or plan a separate bank account for the business.

☐ Create your spreadsheet with four tabs: Products, Orders, Ads, Money.

☐ Check your shortlist of three business names against domain and trademark search.

CHAPTER 4

Niche and Product Research

> **Learning goals:** choose a niche you can understand, use a repeatable filter to shortlist products, and check demand, competition and margin before you commit money.

4.1 Niche first, product second

A **niche** is a group of people with a shared interest or problem, for example "home gym beginners", "pet grooming at home", or "kitchen gadgets for small flats". Products sell better when they solve a clear problem for a clear group. Choosing a niche first makes product selection easier, because you know who you are speaking to and what they care about.

Good niche questions: Do I understand this group? Can I find their online communities? Is there enough demand but not endless competition? Could I write ten honest product descriptions without lying?

4.2 The product research funnel

Start with many ideas and remove weak ones step by step. The funnel below is the method used in this course. Expect to discard 90 percent or more of your first ideas.

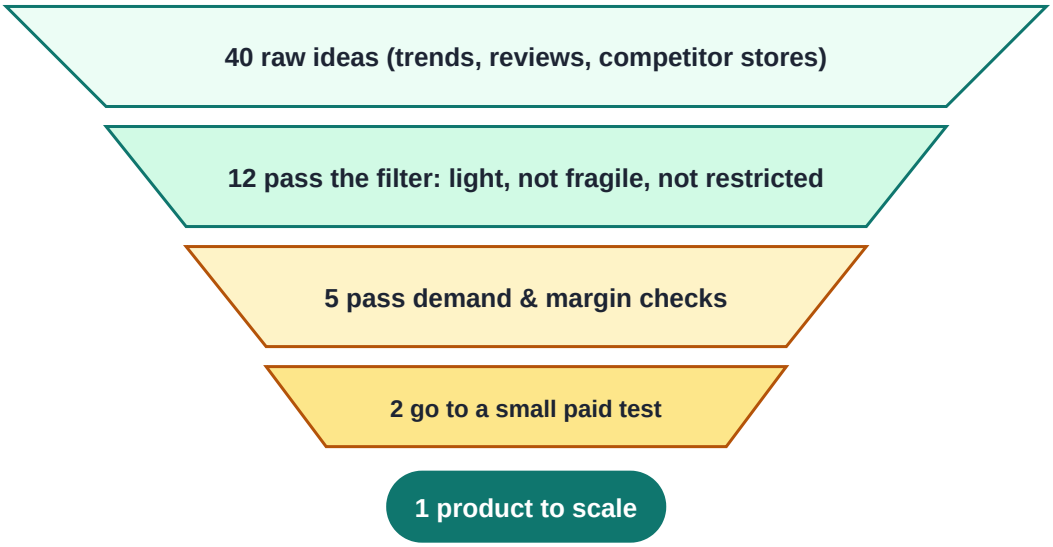


Figure 4.1 · The product research funnel. Each stage asks a harder question and costs more time.

4.3 The first filter: the product checklist

Score each candidate from 0 to 2 on each point (0 = no, 1 = maybe, 2 = yes). Discard anything below 12 out of 16.

Criterion	What a good product looks like
Light and small	Fits in a letter envelope or small box; lowers shipping cost and damage risk
Not fragile	Survives rough handling; no glass or liquids unless packed well
Clear problem	Solves something visible in a short video (e.g. "clean cars without a hose")
Visual appeal	Looks good in a 10-second video or a photo
Not restricted	No medical claims, weapons, age-restricted or regulated goods, and no counterfeit brands
Low return risk	Sizing, colour and quality are predictable; fewer returns
Repeat or add-on potential	Could be sold with accessories or refills
Ethical sourcing	Supplier can explain materials and working conditions

4.4 The second filter: demand evidence

Look for proof that people are already searching for and buying the product:

- **Google Trends:** compare the search interest over 12 months. Is it steady or rising? Beware of a one-week spike.
- **TikTok and Instagram:** search the product name. Look for many different creators, not one viral clip repeated. Check comments for questions and complaints.
- **Marketplace reviews:** read 20 recent reviews on a large marketplace. Note what buyers praise and what they complain about. Complaints show you what to fix in your listing.
- **Meta Ad Library:** search the brand or keyword to see which ads are running. Ads that have run for months are often profitable.

4.5 The third filter: competition and differentiation

If twenty stores sell the same photo, you will compete on price alone, which is the hardest way to win. Ask: can I offer a bundle, a better guide, a faster delivery promise from a local warehouse, a clearer video, or a niche angle (for example, the same blender sold for "meal-prep for students")? Differentiation can be small, but it must be real.

4.6 Margin check before you buy samples

Do the numbers before you buy anything. A product that sells for $30 but costs $14 to ship and advertise is not worth testing. Use this quick rule:

```
Rough margin = Selling price - Supplier cost (incl. shipping) - Estimated ad cost per sale - Fees and tax
```

Chapter 7 explains the full calculation. As a first screen, look for a product where the selling price is at least **3 times** the supplier's landed cost (product plus shipping). A lower ratio can still work for a very cheap product, but leaves little room for ads.

4.7 Keeping a research log

Record every candidate in your Products tab: name, niche, supplier link, supplier cost, shipping time, selling price target, competitor prices, search trend (rising, flat, falling), score, and a one-line decision: test, wait, or reject. A log stops you from repeating the same research and gives you evidence when you explain a decision later.

Avoid these traps

- Products that are trending only because of a viral stunt or a news event.
- Items with fake health or safety claims, or that copy a famous brand's logo or design.
- "Winning product" lists sold by strangers online. Nobody can guarantee a winner.

Practical task 4

☐ Choose three niches you understand and write one paragraph about each customer.

☐ For each niche, list ten product ideas and score them with the 16-point checklist.

☐ Take the top three and complete the demand, competition and margin checks. Record your decision in the log.

CHAPTER 5

Finding and Vetting Suppliers

> **Learning goals:** understand the main supplier types, vet a supplier with a checklist, order samples correctly, and set realistic delivery promises.

5.1 Types of suppliers

Type	Description	Trade-off
Marketplace sellers (e.g. AliExpress, Temu, Alibaba)	Many sellers, very low prices, large catalogues	Quality varies; slow shipping; hard to confirm reliability
Dropshipping platforms (e.g. CJdropshipping, Spocket, Zendrop)	Import products into your store and send orders automatically	Easier to run; monthly fees on some plans; still needs checking
Local wholesalers or distributors	Businesses in your own country that stock goods	Faster shipping and easier returns; often higher prices and minimum orders
Manufacturers (direct)	Factories that make your product or a version of it	Best margins and control; usually needs minimum order quantities, so it is less suited to testing

For a part-time test, start with a dropshipping platform or a local wholesaler that offers a sample. Move to a direct manufacturer only when a product has proven sales and you need better control.

5.2 Supplier vetting checklist

1. **Business information:** does the supplier show a company name, address, contact details and a return policy?
2. **Reviews and history:** read reviews on several independent sites, not only the supplier's own page. Look for patterns, not single angry comments.
3. **Shipping evidence:** ask for typical delivery times to your country, the carrier used, and whether tracking is provided.
4. **Stock:** check that stock is available. Ask how they handle out-of-stock items.
5. **Communication:** send a question and time the reply. Slow or evasive answers are a warning sign.
6. **Packaging:** ask whether they can use your brand name on the packing slip. Many suppliers offer plain packaging.
7. **Quality:** always order a sample yourself before selling.
8. **Terms:** read the refund, damage and lost-parcel policies.

Red flags

Stop and look elsewhere if you see: prices far below all other sellers, no contact details, reviews that all arrived in one week, requests to pay by unusual methods (gift cards, direct transfers to personal accounts), or a product page that copies another brand's photos and text exactly.

5.3 Ordering samples

Order at least two samples of each product you plan to sell, if the cost is reasonable: one in the colour or size you will promote and one from a different batch or seller. Check:

- real colours and sizes compared with the listing photos;
- material feel, weight, finish and stitching or seams;
- packaging condition and how the item arrives (is it damaged, bent, dirty?);
- the actual delivery time, measured from the day you paid to the day the parcel arrived;
- the quality of any manual, label, or accessory.

Take photos and short videos of the sample. You may use these for your own product page if they are clear and honest, and you must not use them to mislead customers.

5.4 Shipping times: the timeline

Delivery time is one of the biggest sources of complaints. Plan your promise around the real timeline, not the supplier's best case.

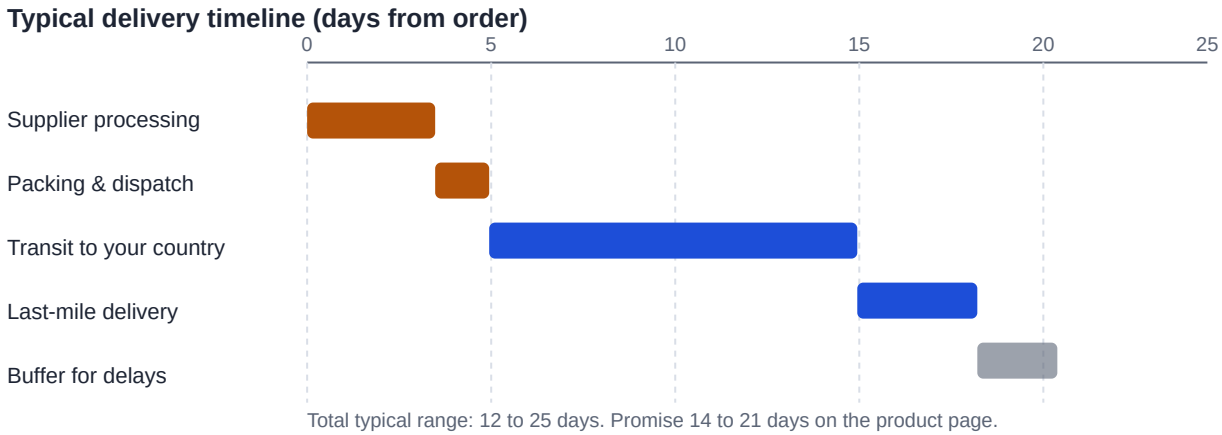


Figure 5.1 · A typical cross-border timeline. Show a realistic range and include the buffer in your promise.

5.5 Contract and communication habits

- Keep every order confirmation and message in one place. Use a shared folder or a note per supplier.
- Never share your customer's personal data beyond what is needed for delivery.
- Agree on a damaged-item and wrong-item process in writing before you start.

- Keep a backup supplier for each top product.

Practical task 5

☐ Find two suppliers for your best product and complete the eight-point vetting checklist for each.

☐ Order one sample from the supplier you prefer. Record the delivery time in days.

☐ Write your shipping promise for the product page, based on the measured timeline plus a buffer.

CHAPTER 6

Building Your Online Store

> **Learning goals:** choose a store platform, set up a clean theme, create the essential pages and policies, and understand the layout that helps customers buy.

6.1 Choosing a platform

Platform	Best for	Notes
Shopify	Most beginners who want a complete, hosted store	Monthly fee; large app store; many dropshipping integrations
WooCommerce (WordPress)	Those who want full control and are comfortable with hosting	More setup work and maintenance; hosting costs
Wix or Square Online	Very simple stores and quick tests	Fewer dropshipping integrations; check features before choosing

Check current pricing and features on each provider's official site. Whichever you choose, pick one platform and stay with it for at least three months.

6.2 Theme and layout

Choose a clean, fast theme with a mobile layout, because most shoppers use phones. Avoid themes with many animations, pop-ups and sliders, which slow pages and distract buyers. Set your brand colours, one heading font and one body font. Upload a simple logo.

6.3 Essential pages

- **Home page:** clear promise, your best product, trust signals (delivery time, returns, contact) and a short "how it works".
- **Product pages:** covered in Chapter 8.
- **Collection pages:** groups of related products, named by customer need.
- **About page:** who you are, why the store exists, and how you care about customers. Be honest; do not invent a factory or a team.
- **Contact page:** email address, contact form, and a realistic reply time.
- **Shipping policy:** countries served, delivery times, costs, and tracking.
- **Returns and refund policy:** conditions, time limits, who pays return shipping, and how refunds are paid.
- **Privacy policy and terms of service:** required in most markets. Use a generator as a starting point, then have the text checked locally.

- **Cookie notice:** needed in many countries if you use tracking or ads.

6.4 The homepage layout

A customer should understand what you sell and why to trust you within five seconds. The wireframe below shows a layout that works well for a single-product or small-range store.

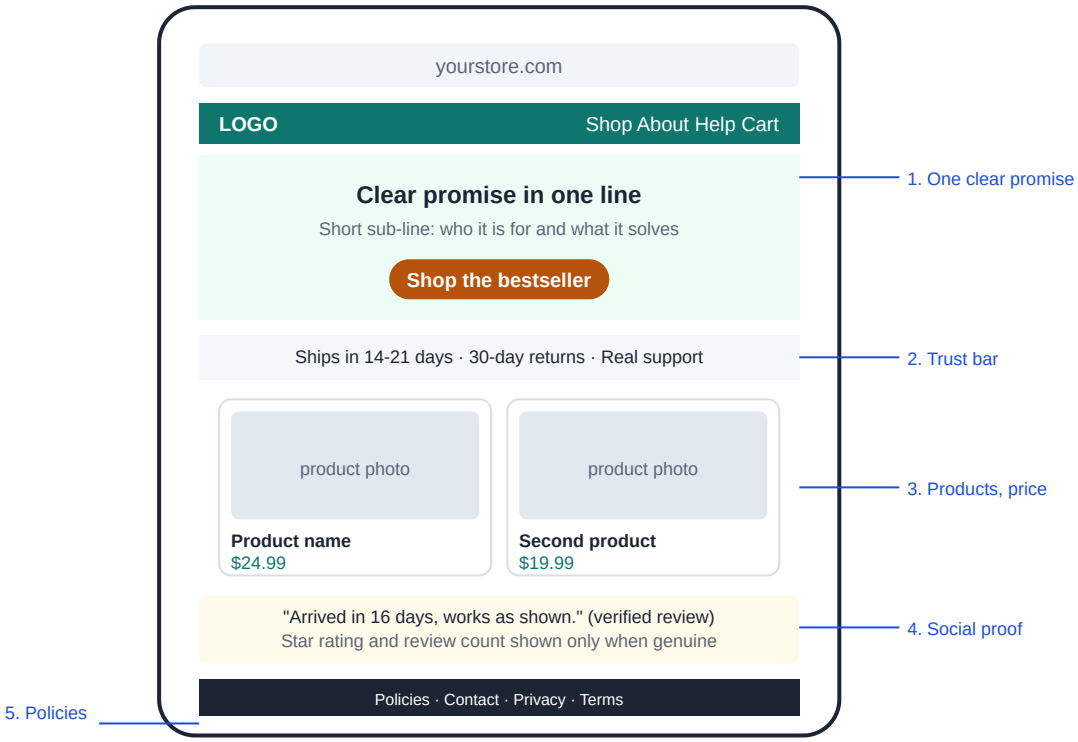


Figure 6.1 · Homepage wireframe for a mobile-first store. Numbers show the order a visitor should see things.

6.5 Apps and settings checklist

☐ Set currency, time zone, and tax settings for your sales countries.

☐ Connect your supplier app and test one order end to end with a test purchase.

☐ Install only the apps you need: reviews, email capture, abandoned-cart email, and analytics. Each app adds code that can slow the store.

☐ Set up order notifications to your phone and email.

☐ Enable two-factor login for the store admin and your ad accounts.

☐ Create a test checkout using the platform's test mode before you go live.

☐ Install an analytics tool and confirm that page views are recorded.

☐ Check the store on a phone, a tablet and a laptop. Read every page aloud once to catch errors.

> **Tip: honest trust signals only**
>
> Trust bars such as "30-day returns" are powerful, but only show them if you really offer them. Never display fake review counts, fake "as seen in" logos, or countdown timers that reset. These break platform rules and consumer law.

Practical task 6

☐ Pick a platform and a theme. Build the homepage using the wireframe above.

☐ Write all eight policy and information pages. Use your own words and check them against your local rules.

☐ Place one test order, check the confirmation email, and cancel it in the supplier system if that is possible.

CHAPTER 7

Pricing, Margins and Money Planning

> **Learning goals:** calculate the true cost of a sale, set a price that leaves room for profit, find your break-even point, and plan a test budget you can control.

7.1 Every cost that matters

Many beginners only count the supplier price. A real sale has several costs:

- **Product cost** from the supplier.
- **Shipping cost** charged by the supplier, or a flat delivery fee you pay.
- **Payment processing fee** charged by your payment provider (commonly a percentage plus a fixed amount per transaction; check your provider's current rates).
- **Platform fee** (monthly subscription, apps, or a transaction fee on some plans).
- **Advertising cost** per sale, often the largest cost (also called customer acquisition cost, CAC).
- **Returns and refunds**, including lost goods and replacements.
- **Discounts** you offer to win the sale.
- **Sales tax or VAT** where it applies to the price you show (which may be included in the price or added at checkout, depending on your market).

7.2 Worked example

Assume a product with a selling price of $39.99. We use simple round numbers so that you can repeat the calculation with your own figures.

Item	Amount per sale	Note
Selling price (incl. tax if your market requires it; excluding here for simplicity)	$39.99	Price the customer pays for the product
Supplier product cost	-$9.00	From your supplier invoice
Supplier shipping	-$4.50	Included in supplier order
Payment processing (about 3% + $0.30)	-$1.50	Check your provider's rates
Platform and app fees (spread per order)	-$1.00	Monthly fee divided by expected orders
Advertising cost per sale	-$12.00	Ad spend divided by number of orders
Returns and refunds allowance (5%)	-$2.00	Estimated loss per sale
Profit per sale	**$9.99**	**About 25% of the price, before any fixed monthly costs**

This shows why advertising and fees must be planned before you pick a price. If ad cost rises to $25 per sale, the profit becomes negative.

7.3 The price waterfall

The chart below shows the same example as a waterfall: money flows in at the top and is subtracted step by step until what remains is your profit.

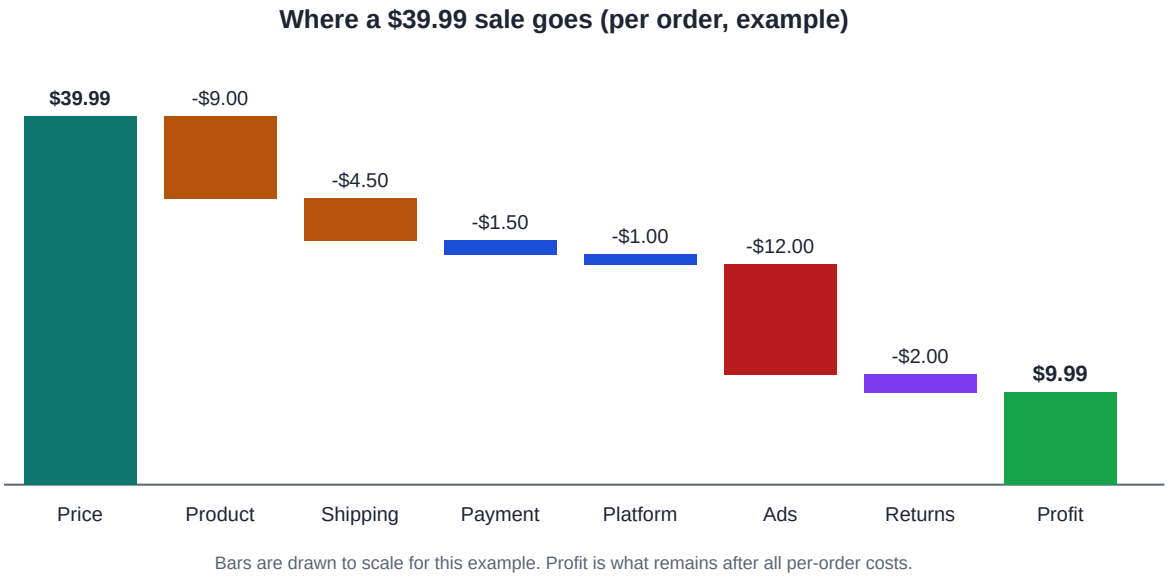


Figure 7.1 · A simplified price waterfall. Advertising is the largest deduction, so it is the cost to control first.

7.4 Break-even point

Break-even tells you how many sales you need to cover your fixed costs for a period:

```
Break-even orders = Fixed costs for the period / Profit per sale (before ads)
```

Example: your fixed monthly costs, not already counted per order, are $60 (for instance an app subscription). Profit per sale after all per-order costs is $9.99, so you need about 6 to 7 sales a month to cover them. Keep these two numbers in your spreadsheet and update them every week.

7.5 Choosing your price

- **Competitor check:** see what similar products sell for. Do not automatically match the lowest price.
- **Perceived value:** a clear guide, a warranty, or faster delivery can justify a higher price.
- **Psychological endings:** prices such as $39.99 often work well, but test them.
- **Bundles:** two items at a combined price raise the order value.
- **Free shipping:** include shipping in the price if customers respond better, but make sure the margin still works.

7.6 Planning the test budget

For a first product test, a practical plan is:

Budget line	Suggested first-test amount (example)
Product samples	$40 to $80 per product
Advertising test	$150 to $300 over 2 to 3 weeks per product
Store and app costs	Monthly plan plus a small reserve
Stop-loss	Stop the product if you spend double its test budget without a profitable sale
Emergency reserve	Keep at least one month of the total budget untouched

These are starting points, not promises. Adjust them to your savings, and never borrow money to test.

7.7 Cash flow

Profit on paper is not cash in the bank. Customers may pay today, while payment from the payment provider arrives after a few days, and supplier invoices may fall due before that. Track money in and money out by date, and keep a cushion of at least two weeks of supplier and ad payments.

Never do these with money

- Pay for ads from money you need for rent, bills or food.
- Increase ad spend on a product just because it has had one lucky day.
- Give deep discounts to every customer to "fix" poor sales. This trains buyers to wait for discounts and shrinks margin.

Practical task 7

☐ Build a price calculator in your spreadsheet using the cost lines in 7.1. Test it with the worked example.

☐ Calculate the profit for your own best product at three different ad costs (low, medium, high).

☐ Set a stop-loss amount for each product test and write it in the Products tab.

CHAPTER 8

Product Pages That Sell

> **Learning goals:** write a clear product title and description, create honest product images, present price and delivery well, and use reviews ethically.

8.1 The job of a product page

A product page answers five questions in order: *What is it? Is it for me? Can I trust this shop? What does it cost, including delivery? How do I buy it?* If any answer is missing, visitors leave. Write your page to answer these questions in the same order.

8.2 Product title

Use the words a buyer would type into a search box, then add one benefit or differentiator. Keep it under about 70 characters.

Weak	Better
"Gadget X2 Pro"	"Foldable Phone Stand for Desk and Bed, Adjustable Height"
"Kitchen tool"	"Stainless Garlic Press with Easy-Clean Design"

8.3 Description structure

1. **Opening line (1 to 2 sentences):** the problem and the solution in plain language.
2. **Key benefits (3 to 5 bullets):** each bullet = a benefit plus the feature that causes it.
3. **Specifications:** size, weight, materials, what is in the box, power requirements, care instructions. Use a small table.
4. **Who it is for, and who it is not for:** honesty here reduces returns.
5. **Delivery and returns:** the realistic delivery range and your return policy in one short paragraph.

> **Writing tip**
> Describe the outcome, not only the object. "Keeps your phone upright for video calls" sells better than "Adjustable aluminium stand". Read the description aloud. If you would not say it to a friend in a shop, rewrite it.

8.4 Images and video

- **Use real photos where possible.** Take them yourself from the sample: plain background, natural light, three angles, one close-up of the key detail, and one photo showing scale (a hand or a coin).

- **Supplier photos:** many are copyrighted by someone else. Use them only if the supplier gives written permission, or redraw or replace them.
- **Short video:** a 10 to 20 second clip showing the product in use is one of the most effective assets for ads and product pages. Film it on a phone in good light.
- **Consistency:** same background, same crop and same size for all product images.
- **Honest representation:** do not show features the product does not have, do not edit colours so that they look different from reality, and do not use models who appear to be a customer if they are not.

8.5 Price, offer and delivery block

Place the price, the variant selector (size, colour), delivery promise, and the add-to-cart button together, above the fold on a phone. Show the realistic delivery range (for example "Delivery in 14 to 21 days") and the return window. Do not hide shipping costs until the final step of checkout: unexpected costs are a major reason for abandoned carts.

8.6 Reviews and social proof

Reviews build trust, but they must be real. Ways to collect genuine reviews:

- Send a follow-up email 7 to 14 days after delivery asking how the product is going, with a direct link to leave a review.
- Include a printed or digital card with a simple request and a support email address.
- Respond publicly and calmly to negative reviews. Fix the issue where you can.

Never write reviews yourself, never ask friends to post fake reviews, and never buy reviews. This breaks platform rules and consumer protection laws in many countries.

8.7 Product page checklist

☐ Title with the main search term and a benefit

☐ Three or more real images, plus one short video if possible

☐ Benefit-led description with specifications and a "who it is for" line

☐ Price, variants, delivery range and returns policy above the fold

☐ Honest review block (or none, until real reviews exist)

☐ Link to the shipping, return and contact pages

☐ Add-to-cart button that works on a phone, tested with a real purchase

Practical task 8

☐ Write the title, opening line and three benefit bullets for your product.

☐ Photograph the sample (or the supplier-approved photos) to the image rules above.

☐ Use the checklist to review your page with a friend who has never seen it. Ask them what they would buy and why.

CHAPTER 9

Driving Traffic and Testing Ads

> **Learning goals:** understand the main traffic channels, run a controlled ad test with clear stop rules, and read the basic numbers (CTR, CPC, conversion rate, ROAS, CPA).

9.1 Traffic channels

Channel	How it works	Best use for a beginner
Paid social (Meta, TikTok)	Short videos and images shown to targeted audiences	Visual products; the main testing channel for most stores
Search ads (Google)	Ads shown when someone searches a term	Products with clear search demand and high intent
Organic social	Free posts, reels, and shorts	Building trust and a following; slow but free
Creators and influencers	Paid or gifted posts by people with an audience	Products that look good on camera; check audience fit
Email and SMS	Messages to people who have bought or subscribed	Repeat sales; abandoned-cart reminders (with consent)
Search engine (SEO)	Pages that rank in free search results	Long-term; needs content and patience

9.2 The sales funnel

Every visitor moves through stages. Your job is to measure each stage so you know where the leak is.

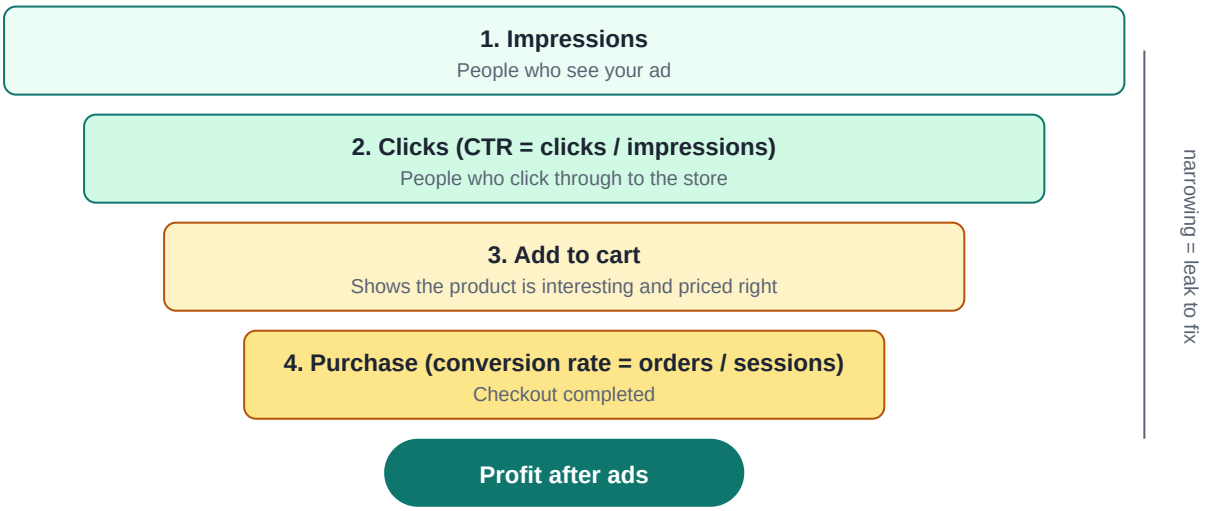


Figure 9.1 · The funnel. A weak click rate points to the ad or image; a weak purchase rate points to the page or price.

9.3 The numbers you must know

Term	Meaning	Rough guide (not a target)
CPM	Cost per 1,000 impressions	Varies widely by market and season
CTR	Click-through rate: clicks / impressions	Above 1% on social is often a healthy start
CPC	Cost per click	Compare with your margin per click
Conversion rate	Purchases / sessions	Often 1% to 3% for a new store; check your own history
CPA	Cost per acquisition (per purchase)	Must be below your profit per sale
ROAS	Revenue from ads / ad spend	Break-even ROAS = 1 / profit margin (e.g. 25% margin means about 4x)

```
Break-even ROAS = 1 / gross margin before ads Example: gross margin 25 % -> 1 / 0.25 = 4.0 (you need $4 revenue per $1 ad spend just to break even)
```

This formula is important: it shows you the minimum return your ads must earn before any profit is made.

9.4 Running a controlled test

1. **Set one objective:** for example, "find out if this product sells at $39.99 to women aged 25 to 40 in one country".
2. **Create 3 to 5 ad creatives** with different hooks: a problem, a demonstration, a comparison, a testimonial from a real customer (with permission).
3. **Spend evenly** across creatives for 3 to 7 days before you judge them.
4. **Judge on purchases, not clicks.** A clicky ad that never sells is still a failed ad.
5. **Apply stop rules:** pause a creative that has spent its test amount with no sale and a very low CTR; stop the product when the stop-loss from Chapter 7 is reached.
6. **Scale slowly:** increase budget by about 20% every few days on a winner, not doubling in one step, which often resets the platform's learning.

9.5 Organic content on a small budget

Create three to four short videos a week that show the product solving the problem. Use a simple structure: hook in the first two seconds, problem, demonstration, result, and a call to action. Reply to comments. Track which posts bring store visits. Organic content also gives you ad creatives and proof of demand.

9.6 Email and retention

Ask for email sign-up in exchange for a real benefit (a guide, a size chart, or an early-access notice). Send a welcome email, a post-purchase thank-you with care tips, and a review request. Abandoned-cart reminders can recover sales, but send them only to people who have agreed to receive marketing messages.

Advertising rules you must follow

- Do not claim cures, guaranteed results, or medical benefits.
- Do not use "before and after" images that are fake, or price claims you cannot back up.
- Do not imitate other brands, use their logos, or use copyrighted music without a licence.
- Do not show children in ways that breach platform policy; never sell age-restricted products to minors.
- Read each platform's current advertising policies before you launch, because they change often.

Practical task 9

☐ Write one objective and a test budget for your first product.

☐ Make three ad creatives with three different hooks (a short video is best).

☐ Set the stop rules in writing before you launch, and calculate your break-even ROAS.

CHAPTER 10

Orders, Shipping and Customer Care

> **Learning goals:** follow an order from payment to delivery, set up tracking and communication, handle returns and complaints calmly, and prevent chargebacks.

10.1 The order lifecycle

Most order problems come from a missing step. Learn the full path so you can see where things went wrong.



Figure 10.1 · The order lifecycle with the two exception paths you must plan for: problems and returns.

10.2 Order processing routine

- Check new orders twice a day (morning and evening). Confirm stock is available before you accept more orders for a product.
- Verify the shipping address before the order is sent. Corrections after dispatch are costly.
- Send a confirmation email that includes the expected delivery window.
- Add tracking numbers to orders as soon as they are available, and send a shipping update to the customer.
- If an order is delayed beyond the promised window, contact the customer before they ask.

10.3 Customer service templates

Good templates save time without sounding robotic. The appendix has ready-to-adapt versions. The key principles are: thank the customer, name the issue, state what you will do and by when, and give a next step.

10.4 Handling problems

Problem	Response plan
Parcel late (within the stated range)	Send the tracking link and an honest update. Explain the typical timeline.
Parcel late (beyond the stated range)	Contact the supplier and carrier the same day. Offer a refund or replacement if the parcel is lost.
Damaged item	Ask for a photo, then send a replacement or refund according to your policy. Claim from the supplier.
Wrong item	Apologise, send the correct item, and ask the customer to keep or return the wrong one as per policy.
Change of mind	Follow your return policy exactly and consistently.
Angry customer	Acknowledge feelings, avoid defensiveness, and state the solution clearly. Never argue in public.

10.5 Chargebacks and disputes

A chargeback happens when a customer asks their bank to reverse a payment. Too many chargebacks can cost you your payment account. Prevent them by using clear billing descriptors, showing a clear store name and contact email, sending tracking numbers, responding quickly to questions, and keeping records of all communication and delivery proof. When a dispute arrives, respond with the evidence within the deadline the provider gives.

> **Customer care is marketing**
>
> A customer who receives a quick, honest answer often becomes a repeat buyer and a reviewer. A poor answer often becomes a public complaint. Treat every support message as part of your advertising budget.

Practical task 10

☐ Place a test order, then follow it through every step in Figure 10.1. Write down how long each step took.

☐ Write your six customer-service templates (use the appendix as a base).

☐ Create a simple support log with date, order number, issue, action taken and result.

CHAPTER 11

Measuring, Optimising and Scaling

> **Learning goals:** build a weekly review routine, read your store analytics, decide what to fix first, and know when a product is ready to scale.

11.1 Your weekly dashboard

Review the same small set of numbers every week. Consistency matters more than complexity.

Metric	Formula	What to look for
Sessions	Visits to the store	Is traffic rising or falling?
Conversion rate	Orders / sessions	Low = page or price problem
Average order value (AOV)	Revenue / orders	Rising AOV lets you afford more ads
Ad spend and ROAS	Spend, revenue from ads / spend	Compare to your break-even ROAS
Profit after ads	Revenue - all costs	The number that decides the business
Refund rate	Refunds / orders	High = product, listing or delivery issue
Average delivery time	Days from order to delivery	Compare to your promise
Repeat customers	Customers with 2+ orders / all customers	Shows brand strength

11.2 Diagnosing problems

Use the funnel from Chapter 9 to find the weak step. The simple logic below helps you decide what to change first.

- **Few visitors:** the problem is traffic. Test new creatives and audiences.
- **Many visitors, few clicks on the product:** the ad or first product image is weak.
- **Many product views, few add-to-carts:** the page, the price or the benefits are not convincing.
- **Many carts, few purchases:** shipping costs are a surprise, checkout is slow, or trust is low.
- **Many orders, high refunds:** the product does not match the description, or delivery is too slow.

11.3 Simple optimisation

Change one thing at a time and measure for at least one week. Good first tests include: a new headline, a new first image, a free-shipping threshold, a bundle offer, or a review request email. Record every change in a log so that you know what caused each result.

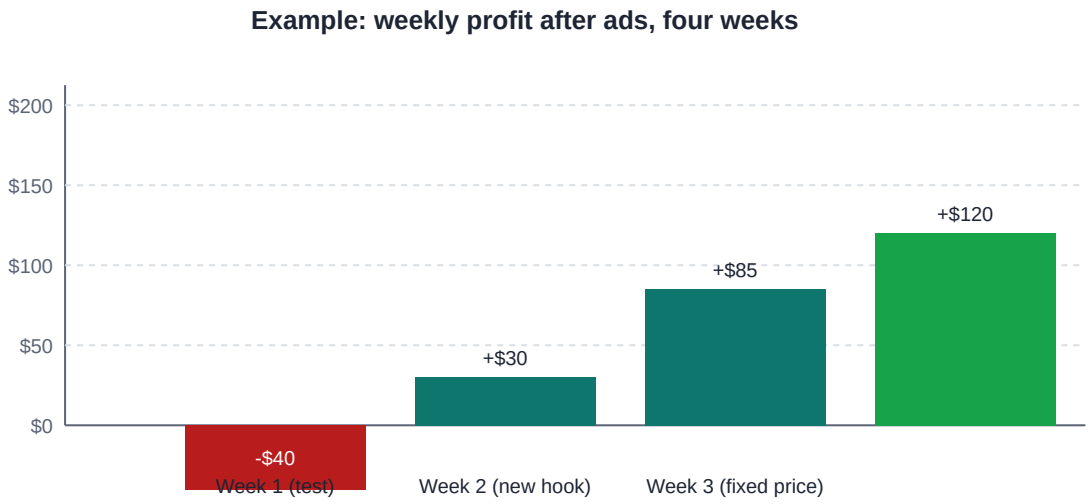


Figure 11.1 · Illustrative numbers only. Notice that the change is logged in each week's label so you can connect cause and effect.

11.4 When to scale

Scale a product only when it meets all of these conditions for at least two consecutive weeks:

☐ Profit after ads is positive, not just ROAS above target

☐ Refund rate is within your acceptable range

☐ Supplier can handle a higher volume, with stock and a delivery time you can promise

☐ Customer messages are manageable within your weekly time budget

☐ Cash reserve is still intact after the planned increase

Scale in steps (about 20% per step, every few days) and watch refunds and delivery complaints closely. Growth can break a process that worked at low volume.

11.5 When to stop or pivot

Stopping is a success if it saves money and time. Stop a product when it has reached its stop-loss, when the supplier cannot deliver reliably, or when the market shows no demand after a fair test. Pivoting means keeping the store and the skills but changing the product, niche or audience. Write the reason in your log so you learn from it.

Practical task 11

☐ Set up your weekly dashboard with the eight metrics above in your spreadsheet or the store's analytics.

☐ Run one optimisation test for two weeks and record the result.

☐ Write a "scale or stop" decision for your main product using the conditions in 11.4.

CHAPTER 12

Legal, Ethical and Risk Management

Learning goals: recognise the main legal duties of an online seller, protect your brand and your customers, and avoid scams, fake reviews and misleading practices.

Not legal advice

This chapter describes common obligations in general terms. Laws differ by country and change over time. For contracts, disputes or any unusual situation, consult a qualified lawyer or your local consumer authority.

12.1 Consumer protection

- **Accurate descriptions:** the product must match your listing in size, material, colour and function.
- **Clear pricing:** the total price, including mandatory fees and delivery, should be visible before checkout.
- **Right to return or cancel:** many markets give buyers a statutory right to cancel online purchases within a set period, sometimes 14 days or more. Check the rules that apply to your customers, not only your own policy.
- **Delivery promises:** if you state a delivery time, you must make a genuine effort to meet it. Do not promise "same-day" if that is not possible.
- **Product safety:** some goods (toys, electrical items, cosmetics, children's products) have specific safety standards and labelling rules. Check before you sell them.

12.2 Honesty in marketing

- No fake reviews, fake ratings, fake "customers are viewing" counters, or false stock messages.
- No fake "original price" crossed out where the item was never sold at that price.
- No medical, weight-loss or cure claims for non-medical products.
- No use of another brand's name, logo or product photos to suggest a connection.

12.3 Intellectual property

Trademarks, copyright, design rights and patents protect many products and images. Selling a counterfeit or a copy of a branded product can lead to account suspension, seizure, fines and legal claims. Before selling, search the brand name in the national trademark register and check whether the product design is protected. Use your own images or licensed stock images, and keep a record of where each image came from.

12.4 Data protection and privacy

- Publish a privacy policy that explains what data you collect and why.
- Ask for consent before sending marketing emails or SMS (for example through a checkbox at sign-up). Keep records of consent.
- Use cookie consent banners where the law requires them (common in the EU, UK and many other markets).
- Share customer data only with the suppliers and service providers who need it to deliver the order.
- Protect your admin accounts with strong passwords and two-factor login.

12.5 Tax and records

Keep records of every sale, refund, supplier invoice, ad invoice and tool subscription for the period required by your tax authority. Separate personal and business spending. Ask for guidance before selling in a country where you have no registration.

12.6 Scams to avoid

Scam type	How to recognise it
"Winning product" and "done-for-you" store sellers	Guaranteed income, pressure to buy today, screenshots with no proof
Fake supplier	Price far below the market, no company information, requests for payment through unusual methods
Account-takeover and phishing	Emails or messages asking you to log in through a link, or to "verify" your store or ad account
Fake platform approvals	Offers to sell you "verified" or "pre-approved" accounts. Using them breaks platform rules
Overpayment scam	A buyer pays more than the price and asks you to refund the difference; the first payment is later reversed

12.7 Ethics: the customer comes first

Ethical dropshipping means selling products you can honestly describe, choosing suppliers whose labour and quality you can explain, and treating customers as you would want to be treated. It also protects your career: a business or a portfolio built on honest work is far easier to explain to future clients and employers.

Practical task 12

☐ Check your legal checklist: policies published, consumer rights confirmed for your sales country, privacy notice in place.

☐ Search your brand and product name in the trademark register for your main market and write down the result.

☐ Write a one-page "rules I will follow" document for your business and sign it with the date.

CHAPTER 13

Your 90-Day Launch Plan

> **Learning goals:** follow a structured 90-day plan with weekly goals, understand the time for each phase, and know what a healthy first quarter looks like.

13.1 The plan on one page



Figure 13.1 · The 90-day plan. Phases overlap in real life; the bars show the main focus of each period.

13.2 Week-by-week goals

Weeks	Focus	Deliverables
1 to 2	Foundation	Business registration started, bank account, toolkit, research log, three niches
3 to 4	Research and sourcing	Five scored products, two suppliers vetted, samples ordered
5 to 6	Store build	Platform live in test mode, theme set, all policy pages, homepage
7 to 8	Products and content	Two product pages, photos or videos, delivery promise, test order
9 to 10	Launch tests	Store live, first ad tests on two products, daily check of spend and messages
11 to 12	Optimise	One change per week, support templates in use, first weekly review written
13	Decide	Scale, pivot or stop each product; 90-day review; plan for the next quarter

13.3 Weekly routine after launch

- **Daily (10 minutes):** new orders, customer messages, ad spend check, any stock alerts.

- **Twice a week (60 to 90 minutes):** ad creative review, one optimisation, content creation.
- **Weekly (45 minutes):** dashboard review, log update, cash check, next week's plan.
- **Monthly (60 minutes):** supplier review, tool costs, legal and policy check, learning review.

13.4 What a good 90 days looks like

A healthy first quarter is one where you have a live store, a small set of tested products, clear data on what works, a working customer-service routine, and a decision for each product. It is not necessarily a profitable quarter. If you finish with knowledge, organised records and a clear next step, the quarter was a success.

> **Keep a learning journal**
>
> At the end of each week, write three lines: what I did, what I learned, what I will do next. After 90 days you will have a document that shows your growth, which is valuable in job applications and client meetings.

Practical task 13

☐ Copy the 13-week plan into your calendar with reminders for each weekly and monthly routine.

☐ Write your 90-day goal in one sentence and your three measurable targets (for example: store live by week 5, two products tested, first ROAS measured).

☐ Schedule your first weekly review for the coming Sunday.

CHAPTER 14

From Store Owner to Digital Career

> **Learning goals:** identify the transferable skills you have built, choose a career path that uses them, and plan how to present them to clients and employers.

14.1 Skills you now have

Skill area	What you did in this course
Market research	Niche analysis, trend checks, competitor research, data logging
E-commerce operations	Store set-up, product listings, order processing, shipping management
Paid advertising	Creative testing, budget control, reading ROAS and CPA
Content and visuals	Product photos, short videos, descriptions, email copy
Analytics	Funnel analysis, dashboards, weekly reviews
Customer service	Templates, complaint handling, dispute prevention
Business basics	Pricing, cash flow, legal awareness, time management

14.2 Career paths that use these skills

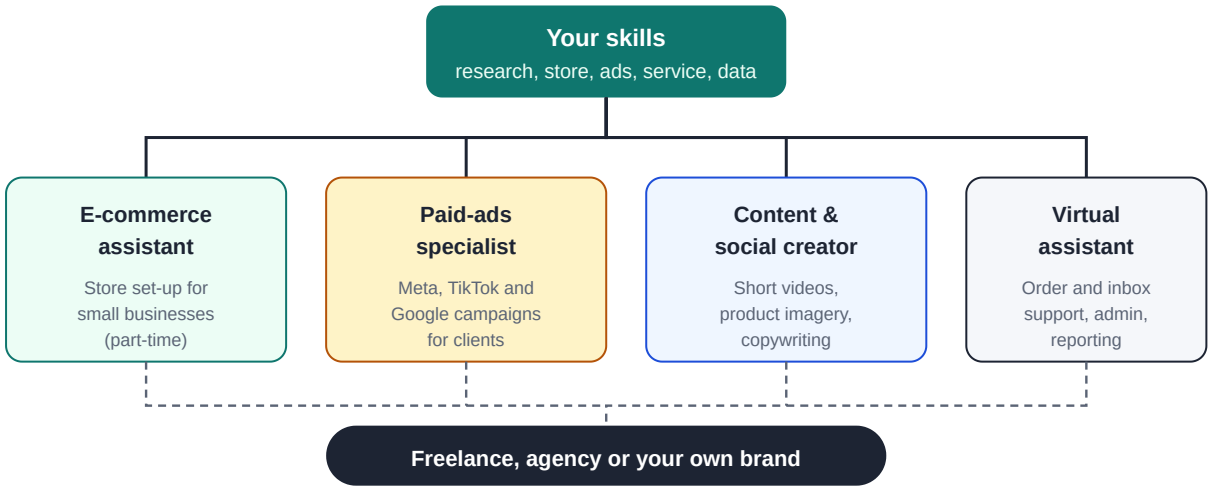


Figure 14.1 · Four entry points into digital work, all built from the skills in this course. Many people move through them in order.

14.3 Building a portfolio

- **Document your store:** screenshots of the store (with your own name or the store's name), a short case study of a product test, and the numbers you are permitted to share.

- **Create sample work:** three example product pages and one ad concept for a brand you admire, clearly labelled as a practice project.
- **Write case studies:** problem, action, result, lesson. Use only real figures and be clear about what you did alone.
- **Share learning:** short posts about what you tested and learned. Be honest about losses as well as wins.

14.4 Finding clients

- Choose one niche of client, such as local shops, small brands on a marketplace, or creators launching a product.
- Offer a fixed-price starter package, for example "store set-up in 10 days" or "one month of ad testing with weekly reports".
- Ask for a clear brief, agree on deliverables and a payment schedule, and put the agreement in writing.
- Never promise income or results. Promise process, quality and communication.

14.5 Working hours and balance

Part-time digital work scales well: one or two clients can fill ten to fifteen hours a week. Protect your time with clear response times, a written scope of work, and an agreed number of revisions. Keep your business records separate from your personal life, and plan rest.

> **Career mindset**
>
> The most valuable outcome of a dropshipping course is not a single store. It is a habit of testing an idea, measuring it honestly, and learning fast. Employers and clients pay for that habit.

Practical task 14

☐ Choose one career path from Figure 14.1 and write why it fits your skills and time budget.

☐ Write two case studies from your own store or practice project using the four-part structure.

☐ List ten people or businesses who could use one of your starter packages. Make a plan to contact three of them this month.

APPENDIX

Glossary, Templates and Checklists

A. Glossary

Term	Meaning
AOV	Average order value: revenue divided by number of orders
Abandoned cart	A cart with items where the customer left before paying
Chargeback	A payment reversed by the customer's bank after a dispute
Conversion rate	Share of visits that end in a purchase
CPA / CAC	Cost per acquisition / customer acquisition cost: ad spend per purchase
CPC / CPM / CTR	Cost per click / cost per thousand impressions / click-through rate
Dropshipping	Selling products that the supplier stocks and ships directly to the customer
Landed cost	The total cost of a product delivered to you: product plus shipping and duties
Margin	Profit as a percentage of the selling price
Niche	A specific group of customers with a shared need or interest
ROAS	Return on ad spend: revenue from ads divided by ad spend
SKU	Stock keeping unit: a unique code for each product variant
Stop-loss	A pre-set limit on how much you will spend on a test before stopping
Variant	A version of a product, such as a size or colour

B. Customer email templates

1. Order confirmation

Hello [Name], thank you for your order [Order number]. We are preparing it now. Expected delivery: [date range]. You will receive a tracking link as soon as the parcel is dispatched. Questions? Reply to this email. [Store name]

2. Shipping update

Hello [Name], good news: your order [Order number] has been shipped. Track it here: [link]. The carrier usually updates within [X] days. [Store name]

3. Delay apology

Hello [Name], I am sorry: your order [Order number] is taking longer than the expected [date range]. The supplier has told us [reason, briefly]. The parcel is now expected by [new date]. If you would prefer a refund instead, reply to this email and I will arrange it. [Store name]

4. Damaged or wrong item

Hello [Name], I am sorry that your item arrived damaged / is not the one you ordered. Could you send a photo of the item and the label? As soon as I have it, I will send a replacement or refund, as you prefer. [Store name]

5. Review request (7 to 14 days after delivery)

Hello [Name], we hope you are enjoying your [product]. If you have a moment, an honest review helps other customers choose: [link]. Thank you for supporting us. [Store name]

6. Return policy reply

Hello [Name], thank you for getting in touch about your return. Returns are accepted within [X] days of delivery, for items in original condition. To start a return, reply with your order number and reason. We will send the return address and the refund will follow within [X] working days of receiving the item. [Store name]

C. Product test scorecard (copy for each product)

Field	Entry
Product name and niche	
Supplier and landed cost	
Selling price and margin	
Break-even ROAS	
Test budget and stop-loss	
Test start and end dates	
Creatives tested (number and hooks)	
Sessions, add-to-cart rate, conversion rate	
Spend, orders, ROAS, profit after ads	
Refunds and delivery complaints	
Decision: scale / pivot / stop	
Reason and lesson learned	

D. Pre-launch checklist

☐ Business registered (or confirmed not required) and tax duties understood
☐ Separate bank account and receipt folder
☐ Supplier vetted, sample received and checked, delivery time measured
☐ Store live, mobile tested, checkout tested with a real purchase
☐ Privacy policy, terms, shipping, returns, contact and cookie notice published
☐ Product images are original or licensed; product claims are accurate
☐ Trademark check completed; product is not counterfeit or restricted
☐ Analytics installed and tested; order notifications working
☐ Customer templates saved; weekly review date in calendar
☐ Stop-loss and budget written down before the first ad

E. Further learning (verify current versions)

- Your national tax authority and business registration office (for registration and tax rules).
- Your national consumer protection authority (for seller obligations and cancellation rights).
- Official help centres of your store platform, your payment provider, and each ad platform (for current policies and fees).

- National trademark databases (for brand checks).
- Free courses on analytics and digital marketing from major learning platforms and from the ad platforms themselves.

Final reminder

No course, tool or supplier can guarantee profit. Your results will come from careful research, honest products, disciplined testing and good customer care. Start small, keep records, and protect your time and money.